And Then – Hanadi and Lynndie

By Amelia Arenas

INTRODUCTION

Suicide bombers are today's weapon of choice. An action that was once so surprising, horrific, and terrifying has now become the daily fare of the nightly news. In terms of casualties, suicide attacks are the most efficient form of terrorism. From 1980 to 2001, suicide attacks accounted for 3 percent of terrorist incidents but caused half of the total deaths due to terrorism—even if one excludes the unusually large number of fatalities of 9/11. Into this boiling cauldron of terror, a new element has been added—women as suicide bombers. The success of suicide bombers considerably depends upon surprise and accessibility to targets. Both of these requirements have been met by using women. In her play And Then, Amelia Arenas has created a 1st person account of a female suicide bomber. Meet Hanadi Jaradat

I. Hanadi

[She reads from a piece of paper in front of a video camera. A Palestinian flag hangs in the background.]

This is the last statement of Hanadi Jaradat, your martyr, spoken before the Haifa operation.

Allah, Father of all things! Allah, the merciful ... ! *[She drops the sheet.]*

I was there.

The fire spread from my breast like thunder. But not a single one of those strangers died before I did.

I was prepared.

Now they call me a terrorist. Yesterday, I was Hanadi.

* * * * *

And what ever happened to him - that good-looking, well-to-do boy I was supposed to marry?

And what about that other one. Remember, Mother?

The one Father never let me talk to.

* * * * *

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I feared the strength of a man's arms and my mother called me cold

because I couldn't stand the noise of children.

But that husband and those children I was to have one day

blew up with me last night.

Last night ...

My hunger for love

was not as great as my rage.

* * * * *

They said that mother collapsed when she saw my picture in the news. She thought I was working late ...

Mother!

Don't look at those pictures! You won't find your child there. She's a ghost now.

She will be climbing the chestnut tree in your backyard forever.

* * * * *

Father,

Remember how you never let me go out?

I hid under the covers all night with a tiny mirror in my hand, playing with that dried-up lipstick I found in Mother's trunk.

I wanted to be like the woman in those pictures - the one your father married and died young.

The one from Jordan.

The one with the big hat

and a cigarette in her hand.

I used to think that

if I looked at her long enough without blinking, I could make her smile.

You never let me go out, Father. I was supposed to hit the books

and quit dreaming about faraway places and pretty ghosts.

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And I did what you said. Didn't I?

* * * * *

As far back as I can remember, you've said again and again "This land is ours!

We have to be better than them.

They are the sort that suffers out loud. We are the sort that remembers."

Did you understand my death, Father?

Now you say that you won't ever mourn me because I made you proud.

Weren't you proud of me back then?

Do you ever cry for me now, Father?

* * * * *

And you, neighbor?

I once walked by your streets,

and you looked at me with a sly glance. I covered my head with a black scarf but I painted my lips bright red.

You hid your girls in your houses

and your sons smoked under the elm tree while I was earning a living.

* * * * *

Look at me now, neighbor! LOOK!

Don't turn the TV off!

You don't have to peek

through a crack in your window anymore.

I am the girl your sons could have never married.

You can look at my mangled corpse and cry. Now I am your martyr.

I am a scar you'll flaunt.

Look at me, neighbor!

LOOK!

Memorize my horror.

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I died for YOUR sons-

the ones who squatted all day long waiting for a job,

when I was at work.

* * * * *

I didn't put on the pretty dress and go to that party,

just as you said, Father.

I obeyed.

I dressed myself in the pride of your fathers. And I took with me

those loud words you spoke.

They were all with me last night. They were the fuel that turned me and those strangers into a wave of blood.

* * * * *

Remember the wounded pigeon we brought home?

Remember how you made him better? We called him Ibrahim.

Remember how, a few days later, when I returned from school,

we found him stiff in that cardboard box?

Remember how I begged you,

"Father, make him better!"

But you didn't.

You couldn't.

We buried him in our backyard. I sat on your lap and cried.

But you didn't dry my tears. You said,

"The salt of sorrow shapes the soul."

You told me it was time to do my homework.

* * * * *

And Fadi? OURFADI!

He blew up with his homework in his hand. And you could not bring him back either.

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* * * * *

I wish you had held me in your arms a little longer ... I wish I was buried in that cardboard box.

Father!

Don't look away now!

Watch me!

I am a cloud of stench. Be proud of me! Listen to me!

ALLAH, FATHER OF ALL THINGS be proud of me!

THIS is my wedding day!

* * * * *

TRANSITION

Since the War on Terror began on 9/11, we've captured hundreds of Islamic terrorists along with the capture of Saddam Hussein himself. The War against Iraq has brought in thousands more prisoners with potential knowledge of upcoming terror attacks.
Unfortunately, when a capture is publicized, terrorists quickly change locations, plans, and communication methods. Thus, any intelligence we can gather from such captures is only good for a short time. The question becomes, should we torture these captures to obtain the information while it's still good?

In 2004, photographs of abuses at Abu Ghraib shocked the world. Seven people were charged, but the face of the scandal will always be Lynndie England, the 21-year-old private grinning at the camera. She wasn't the only woman soldier in the photographs - Sabrina Harman and Megan Ambuhl were both court martialled for their roles - but England was the most arresting looking, like a 14-year-old boy who shouldn't have been there in the first place. Her legal defense, that she was unduly influenced by Specialist Charles Graner, the father of her child and the only soldier still serving time for abuses at Abu Ghraib, was compounded outside the courtroom by assumptions about her background; that she came from a place where people didn't know better. In another excerpt from And Then by Amelia Arenas we hear Lynndie England's story.

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III. Lynndie

Hi there!

I'm Lynndie England. PRIVATE England!

I'm an American soldier!

Oops, sorry! I was an American soldier. And I kicked ass, damn it!

But where the hell am I now?

The stupid lawyers don't even let me talk in court. I could say a thing or two about my "superiors" ...

I'm toast.

I'm twenty-one

but they'll put me away until I croak.

And, guess what? I'm pregnant.

As if I needed this ...

* * * * *

Oh! Gimme a break! We all did it.

Mike was there. Watching it all.

I was crazy about him, He was SO bad!

I used to look at him and think, wouldn't it be cool to be him?

* * * * *

They're making a big deal on account that I'm a woman. It's not like I'd never seen a gun, OK?

I learned to shoot at nine.

Dad taught me how to hunt deer. And I was good at it, too.

But then we had to drag the dead thing into the van.

That was hard.

He let me ride in the back.

I wanted to look at the buck. He was so big!

His eyes were still open.

His tongue hanging out from his mouth.

I touched him.

He was still warm.

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A beautiful thing, you know ...

If I live again, I want to be one of them, you know. A big buck. And I won't let anyone get me, damn it. I'll fight back.

Anyway.

Dad would have killed me if he'd caught me petting it.

I just wanted to know what the deer thought when he froze, saw me point the gun at him and heard the blast.

I asked Dad,

"What's gonna happen now

with the buck's kids and his wife?" What can I say, I was just a stupid kid.

Dad cracked up.

I was so pissed!

I jumped out of the van.

He goes, "How can you be so dumb! Deer don't have wives or kids. They're not like us. They're beasts.

We've been killing them and eating them since God knows when.

So don't go stupid on me now. Get in the van!"

I thought, "Wait.

We don't even eat the whole deer.

We dump most of it over the cliff and let it rot."

Anyway.

It's not like he was mad or anything. Actually, when we got home he said, "You're a swell kid, you know?

You wacked this one all alone.

Give Daddy a kiss!"

I hated Dad's kisses.

His mouth tasted like an ashtray full of whiskey. But I liked the way he looked at me.

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Not at home, when we were out.

When we were out I did not feel like a girl.

* * * * *

That day Mom was a mess

when she saw my dress all bloody.

Just like the day I said

I was joining the army.

What does she know?

She's always baking something. Yakking on the phone with her friends. Watching soap operas.

I had to get the hell out of that dump or else I'd end up like her.

* * * * *

Man, if you had seen the party they threw me! Billy left the gas station early,

Molly and Jake came

all the way from Norfolk.

And the kids from the factory came too.

I still had a hangover when I got to the base ... So, I get into that plane.

And then,

Iraq, baby.

Wow,

what a mess.

You had to see it! Bombs every day, Everywhere.

And those Arabs

spat in our faces when we walked by their homes. Two guys in my unit croaked.

Right there, practically in front of me. They were not even fighting.

Just guarding the streets.

That's how these animals pay us back. After we get that fat pig out of there and we're

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trying to teach them how to live like human beings!

Animals! That's what they are!

* * * * *

One day we

took the creeps out of their cages.

We got them naked.

I held one of them on a dog leash. and put a panty over his head.

One of us took a leak on a guy's face and all that ...

So, what's the big deal?

The dogs were scary, though. I'll give you that.

But, hellooool It was IRAQ!

It's not like we were on vacation.

What do you think we got?

Stale hamburgers and flat beer. And what was going on every day? A LOT OF NOTHING.

Except another guy you just met got shot. The rest was all,

"Yes, sir! Yes, sir! Yes, sir!"

Oh, please.

Somebody has to look bad

so that it all looks good, I GUESS.

* * * * *

But wait, what was I talking about? Oh, yeah. The guy on the leash. At some point, I look at him

and the coward covers his face

and starts crying like a baby.

Right there and then,

I thought of that buck I shot when I was nine. He never closed his eyes.

He kept staring at me even after he died.

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I still see him sometimes in my head

and I get all sweaty.

I wish I could talk to him and tell him, "You're a real man.

Not like this scum here.

I didn't really mean to kill you, buddy. I was just a kid.

I don't even like venison."

* * * * *

Hey, what are you looking at? Did I offend you?

Well, pardon me, SIR.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

KS State Qualifier

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